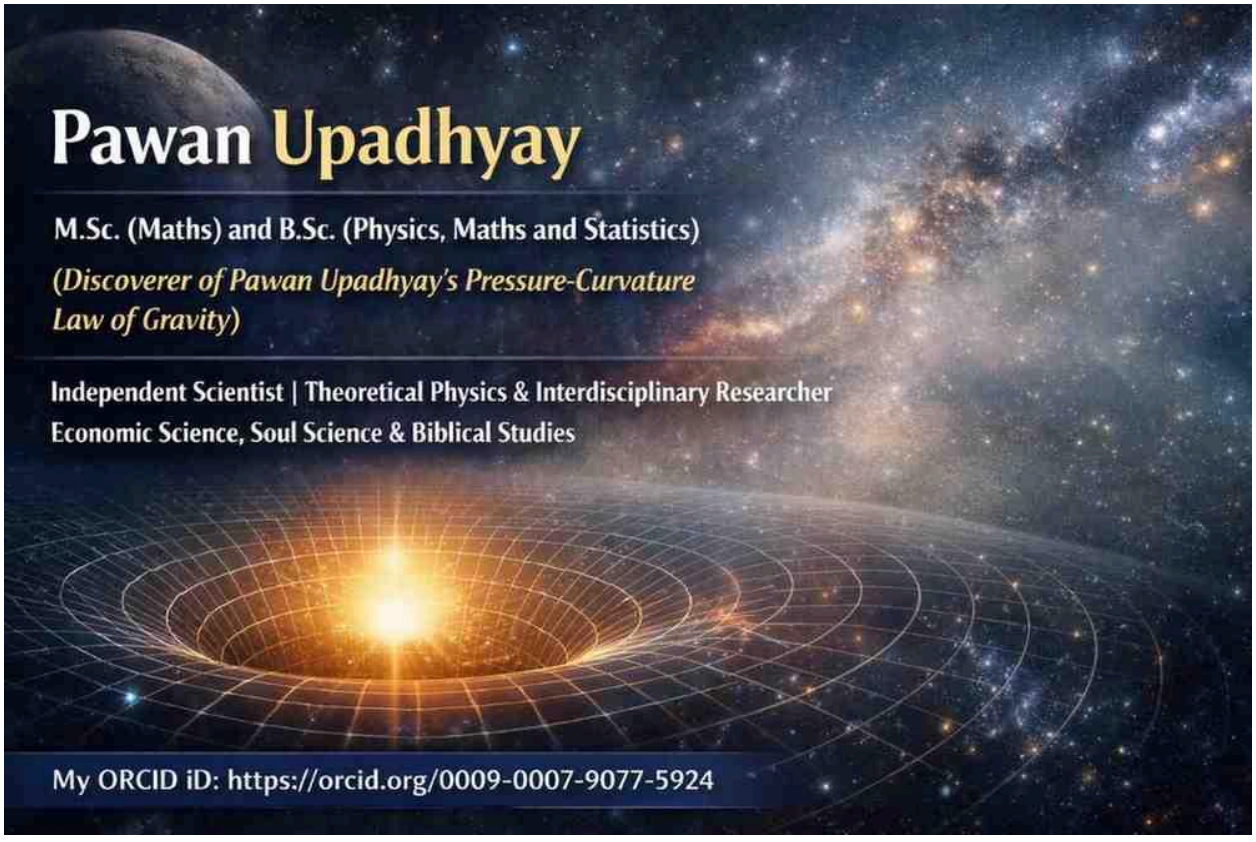
Virtue and Virtuous in Biblical and Linguistic Perspective

A Comparative Study of the English, Greek, Hebrew, and Aramaic/Syriac Terms

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Abstract

The English words **virtue** and **virtuous** are frequently used in Christian teaching to describe moral goodness, purity, or exemplary character. However, a biblical examination reveals that

these concepts cannot be reduced to a single lexical equivalent in the biblical languages. This research paper investigates the semantic fields associated with “virtue” and “virtuous” in English, Greek, Hebrew, and Aramaic/Syriac, with particular attention to Greek **ἀρετή (*aretē*)**, Hebrew **חַיִל (*ḥayil*)**, and the related Aramaic/Syriac **חיל / ܚܝܠ (*ḥyl/ḥaylā*)**. It also examines the historical development of the English *virtue* from Latin *virtus* through Old French and Middle English. Special attention is given to Proverbs 31:10, 2 Peter 1:5, Philippians 4:8, and 1 Peter 2:9. The study argues that biblical virtue is best understood not simply as moral purity or passive goodness, but as **strength, excellence, worth, and moral character expressed through faithful action**. At the same time, the paper emphasizes that lexical parallels must not be treated as exact equivalents: each word must be interpreted according to its linguistic and literary context.

Keywords: virtue, virtuous, ἀρετή, *aretē*, חַיִל, *ḥayil*, Aramaic, Syriac, Proverbs 31, 2 Peter 1, biblical ethics, moral excellence

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1. Introduction

The concepts of **virtue** and **virtuous character** occupy an important place in biblical ethics. Scripture repeatedly calls God's people to lives characterized by righteousness, holiness, wisdom, courage, faithfulness, self-control, generosity, and love. Yet the English word *virtue* can sometimes conceal the richness of the original biblical terminology.

For example, Proverbs 31:10 traditionally asks:

“Who can find a virtuous woman?”

The Hebrew expression is **אֵשֶׁת־חַיִל (*ʾēšet ḥayil*)**, literally something like “a woman of *ḥayil*.” The Hebrew term *ḥayil* possesses a broad semantic range that includes strength, force, ability, wealth, resources, and military force, as well as qualities of worth and capability.

In the New Testament, the Greek term most directly associated with “virtue” is **ἀρετή (*aretē*)**. Classical Greek lexicography shows that *aretē* can refer to excellence of many kinds, including physical ability, courage, moral excellence, merit, distinction, and praiseworthy qualities.

The Aramaic/Syriac linguistic field associated with **ḥyl** likewise contains the ideas of army, force, power, strength, ability, authority, and intrinsic potency.

The English word itself has a similarly broad history. Latin *virtus* could refer to moral strength, excellence, courage, valor, worth, and strength; Old French *vertu* retained meanings such as strength, vigor, moral strength, qualities, and abilities.

Therefore, the central research question of this study is:

What does “virtue” mean when the semantic fields of the English, Greek, Hebrew, and Aramaic/Syriac terms are examined together, and what does this contribute to a biblical understanding of virtuous character?

The thesis of this paper is that **biblical virtue should be understood as excellence and strength of character expressed in conduct that is worthy, faithful, righteous, and beneficial**. This definition incorporates—but is not limited to—moral purity.

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2. Methodology and Scope

This study employs a comparative lexical and contextual method.

First, the historical development of the English words *virtue* and *virtuous* is examined. Second, the semantic fields of the principal Greek, Hebrew, and Aramaic/Syriac terms are considered. Third, selected biblical passages are examined in their immediate contexts. Finally, the findings are synthesized into a theological description of biblical virtue.

The study does **not** assume that words in different languages are exact equivalents. Semantic fields frequently overlap without being identical. Therefore, the relationship can be represented as:

English concept ↔ Greek concept ↔ Hebrew concept ↔ Aramaic/Syriac concept

rather than:

one English word = one Hebrew/Aramaic/Greek word.

This distinction is essential for responsible biblical word study.

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3. The English Word “Virtue”

3.1 Historical Development

The English noun **virtue** entered the language around the beginning of the thirteenth century in the form *vertu*. It came through Anglo-French/Old French *vertu* from Latin **virtus**. Historical sources describe Latin *virtus* as including meanings such as moral strength, high character, goodness, valor, bravery, courage, excellence, and worth.

Old French *vertu* likewise carried the meanings:

- force,
- strength,
- vigor,
- moral strength,
- qualities,
- abilities.

Thus the historical development of the English word is important because its original semantic range was considerably broader than the modern association of virtue with moral purity alone.

The word **virtuous**, appearing in English around 1300, originally included the senses "characterized by vigor or strength," "valiant," "hardy," and "courageous," before developing more strongly toward moral excellence and conformity to religious law.

The specialized association of *virtue* with chastity or sexual purity developed later, particularly in reference to women.

Consequently, the modern English reader should be cautious about automatically interpreting "virtuous" as synonymous with "sexually pure."

3.2 Virtue as Power or Efficacy

An additional historical development is especially significant for Bible study.

The expression **"by virtue of"** preserves an older meaning involving efficacy or inherent power. Medieval English biblical usage could employ *virtue* in contexts where modern translations use **power**.

This older meaning explains why some traditional English Bible passages can use "virtue" in contexts where the underlying idea is not simply moral character.

Thus, a responsible interpretation must ask:

Is "virtue" describing moral excellence, or is it describing effective power or potency?

The surrounding biblical context must determine the answer.

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4. The Greek Word ἀρετή (*aretē*)

4.1 Basic Semantic Range

The principal New Testament Greek term for virtue is:

ἀρετή (*aretē*)

The noun is feminine and is commonly translated:

- virtue,
- excellence,
- moral excellence,
- goodness,
- praise,
- excellencies.

Classical Greek lexicography demonstrates that *aretē* possessed a broad semantic range. It could describe excellence in a person or thing, physical qualities, courage or valor, moral virtue, good character, distinction, and even praiseworthy achievement.

The *Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament and Other Early Christian Literature* describes *aretē* as a term associated with consummate excellence or merit and notes its connection with excellence of character and qualities worthy of recognition.

Therefore, translating *aretē* simply as “being a good person” does not capture the full semantic range.

4.2 ἀρετή in 2 Peter 1:5

A central New Testament passage is 2 Peter 1:5:

“Add to your faith virtue…”

The Greek text contains:

τὴν ἀρετήν

—the accusative singular of *aretē*.

Peter presents *aretē* as part of a sequence:

faith → virtue → knowledge → self-control → perseverance → godliness → brotherly affection → love.

This sequence demonstrates that virtue belongs to the formation of Christian character. It is not presented as an isolated external reputation.

In this context, *aretē* may appropriately be understood as **excellence or moral vigor that gives visible expression to faith**. Classical and New Testament lexicographical evidence supports this broader interpretation.

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5. ἀρετή in Philippians 4:8

Paul uses *aretē* again in Philippians 4:8:

“If there be any virtue, and if there be any praise, think on these things.”

The word appears in the phrase:

εἴ τις ἀρετή

“if there is any virtue/excellence.”

The context is significant. Paul has just called believers to think about things that are:

- true,
- honorable,
- just,
- pure,
- lovely,
- commendable.

Virtue therefore functions within a broader moral vocabulary.

The emphasis is not merely on avoiding immoral thoughts but on filling the mind with qualities that are **excellent and worthy of commendation**.

Thus *aretē* in this context is fundamentally positive.

Virtue is not merely the absence of vice.

It is the presence of excellence.

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6. ἀρετή and the Excellencies of God

A particularly significant use occurs in 1 Peter 2:9, where the plural **ἀρετάς (*aretas*)** is used.

The term can refer to God's **excellencies** or praiseworthy qualities. Lexical sources note that the plural can refer to the glorious qualities or excellencies of God.

This broadens our understanding further.

Virtue is not merely a human ethical achievement.

The Christian is called to proclaim God's excellencies and to reflect God's character.

Therefore, biblical virtue has a theological dimension:

Virtue is ultimately related to the character and works of God and to the believer's transformation into a life that reflects them.

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7. The Hebrew Word חַיִל (*ḥayil*)

7.1 Semantic Range

The Hebrew noun:

חַיִל (*ḥayil*)

is particularly important for understanding the Old Testament concept associated with “virtuous.”

Its semantic field includes:

- strength,
- force,
- ability,
- efficiency,
- wealth,
- resources,
- army,
- military force,
- capability,
- worth,
- valor.

Proverbs 31:10 uses *ḥayil* in the phrase:

אֵשֶׁת־חַיִל (*ʾēšet ḥayil*)

The lexical entry for Proverbs 31:10 identifies *ḥayil* with strength, efficiency, wealth, and related meanings.

This explains why translations vary considerably.

Some use:

“virtuous woman.”

Others use:

“excellent wife,”
“woman of noble character,”
“woman of valor,”
“capable woman,”
“woman of worth.”

These differences are not necessarily contradictory. They reflect different aspects of the Hebrew semantic field.

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8. Proverbs 31:10 and the Woman of Ḥayil

Proverbs 31:10 provides perhaps the clearest Old Testament example of the concept under investigation:

“Who can find a virtuous woman? for her price is far above rubies.”

The Hebrew does not literally contain an adjective corresponding exactly to modern English *virtuous*. Instead, it describes a woman as **ʾēšet ḥayil**, “a woman of *ḥayil*.”

The Septuagint translates this expression with:

γυναῖκα ἀνδρείαν

which can convey the sense of a courageous, vigorous, or valiant woman.

This is significant because it confirms that the conceptual field extends beyond sexual purity.

The woman of Proverbs 31 is portrayed as:

- trustworthy,
- industrious,
- economically capable,
- wise,
- generous,
- prepared,
- strong,
- compassionate,
- productive,
- God-fearing.

Her “virtue” is demonstrated through the whole pattern of her life.

The passage therefore illustrates a fundamental biblical principle:

Virtue is character demonstrated through faithful action.

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9. The Context of Proverbs 31

The meaning of *ḥayil* cannot be separated from the description that follows Proverbs 31:10.

The woman:

1. brings good rather than harm to her husband;
2. works willingly;
3. provides food;
4. purchases and manages property;
5. plants a vineyard;
6. conducts economic activity;
7. helps the poor;
8. prepares for future circumstances;
9. speaks wisdom;
10. teaches kindness;
11. fears the LORD.

Her value is not based on a single characteristic.

Her virtue is **integrated character**.

She possesses ability, but her ability is governed by wisdom.

She possesses resources, but her resources are used responsibly.

She possesses strength, but her strength serves others.

She possesses authority within her household, but it is expressed through responsibility rather than selfish domination.

Thus *ḥayil* in Proverbs 31 is best understood as a comprehensive description of **strength, capability, worth, and excellence expressed through godly living**.

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10. The Aramaic/Syriac Semantic Field

The Aramaic and Syriac evidence provides an important comparative perspective.

The Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon identifies **ḥyl / ḥylā** as a noun associated with “army” and “force.” Its semantic range also includes:

- power,
- strength providing ability,
- intrinsic potency,
- authority,
- strength,
- essence,
- wealth,
- abundance.

The Syriac examples include the expression “to the best of my ability,” illustrating the relationship between *ḥyl* and capacity or ability.

The related verb can mean:

- to strengthen,
- to be strong,
- to prevail,
- to carry out sacred military service,
- and, in some traditions, to be exalted.

This is particularly significant because it demonstrates that the Semitic concept underlying *ḥyl/ḥayil* is fundamentally associated with **strength and capacity**.

However, the Aramaic/Syriac term should not simply be declared synonymous with Greek *aretē*. They overlap in semantic territory, but they belong to different languages and literary traditions.

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11. Comparative Analysis

The major terms can be summarized as follows:

Language	Term	Principal semantic field
English	virtue	moral excellence, goodness, strength, worth
English	virtuous	excellent, morally good, historically strong/valiant
Greek	ἀρετή (*aretē*)	excellence, virtue, moral goodness, merit
Hebrew	חַיִל (*ḥayil*)	strength, ability, force, valor, resources, worth
Aramaic/Syriac	ḥyl / ܚܝܠ (*ḥaylā*)	force, strength, ability, power, capacity

The terms overlap around several central concepts:

1. Strength

Virtue is associated with strength rather than weakness.

2. Excellence

Virtue represents something that is genuinely excellent or worthy.

3. Worth

A virtuous person is portrayed as possessing qualities of genuine value.

4. Capability

Virtue is capable of producing action.

5. Moral character

The concept ultimately includes goodness and righteousness.

6. Visible conduct

Biblical virtue is expressed through deeds rather than remaining merely theoretical.

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12. Virtue Is More Than Moral Purity

One of the major conclusions of this study is that **virtue should not be reduced to sexual purity**.

Sexual purity is a legitimate biblical virtue, but the lexical evidence demonstrates that neither *aretē* nor *ḥayil* is limited to that meaning.

The historical English evidence likewise shows that *virtue* originally possessed meanings involving strength, vigor, courage, excellence, and ability. The association with chastity became more specialized later.

Consequently, the biblical concept is considerably broader.

A person may be sexually pure but still lack:

- honesty,
- courage,
- wisdom,
- generosity,
- diligence,
- compassion,
- faithfulness,
- self-control.

Biblical virtue encompasses the whole person.

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13. Virtue as Strength Directed Toward Goodness

The lexical evidence suggests a useful synthesis:

Strength by itself is not virtue.

Strength can be used destructively.

Likewise:

Ability by itself is not virtue.

Ability can be used selfishly.

And:

Knowledge by itself is not virtue.

Knowledge can be used deceptively.

Virtue arises when strength, ability, knowledge, resources, and character are directed toward what is good, righteous, and worthy.

This is visible in Proverbs 31.

The woman possesses ability, but she uses it for her household and community.

She possesses economic competence, but she uses it responsibly.

She possesses strength, but it produces productive and beneficial action.

Her character is therefore not merely admirable in theory; it is **effective in practice**.

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14. Virtue and Christian Spiritual Formation

The New Testament makes the same principle explicit in 2 Peter 1.

Peter does not treat virtue as the final destination.

Instead, virtue exists within a developing pattern of Christian maturity:

Faith → Virtue → Knowledge → Self-control → Perseverance → Godliness → Brotherly Affection → Love.

This indicates that Christian virtue is relational and developmental.

Faith must become character.

Character must become disciplined knowledge and conduct.

Discipline must become perseverance.

Perseverance must become godliness.

Godliness must become love.

Thus biblical virtue is not merely a static possession.

It is a quality of life that participates in spiritual formation.

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15. Virtue and the Mind

Philippians 4:8 adds another dimension.

Paul connects *aretē* with the things upon which believers are to focus their minds.

Virtue therefore concerns not only behavior but also **attention and thought**.

What a person continually considers influences the character that person develops.

The biblical pattern can therefore be expressed as:

Thought → character → action → habit → life.

This means virtue cannot be separated from the formation of the inner person.

External morality without internal transformation is insufficient.

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16. Virtue and the Character of God

First Peter 2:9 gives the concept a distinctly theological direction.

Believers are called to proclaim the **excellencies** of God.

This suggests that Christian virtue is not ultimately defined by human preference.

Its highest reference point is God.

The Christian question is therefore not merely:

“What qualities does society consider admirable?”

but:

“What qualities correspond to the character, will, and purposes of God?”

This gives biblical virtue its theological foundation.

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17. Virtue as Character Made Visible

The combined lexical evidence allows us to formulate a practical model:

Strength

A person possesses capacity and courage.

↓

Character

That strength is governed by moral principles.

↓

Wisdom

The person knows how and when to use it.

↓

Action

The quality becomes visible in conduct.

↓

Benefit

The person's strength becomes useful to others.

↓

Excellence

The life demonstrates genuine *aretē* and *ḥayil*.

This is why biblical virtue is not merely an internal feeling.

It is **character translated into action**.

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18. A Proposed Definition of Biblical Virtue

Based upon the evidence examined in this study, the following definition is proposed:

Biblical virtue is the strength and excellence of character by which a person, oriented toward God, consistently expresses what is good, righteous, worthy, wise, faithful, and beneficial through thought, word, and action.

This definition contains several dimensions.

Ontological dimension

Virtue concerns what a person **is**.

Moral dimension

Virtue concerns what is **good and righteous**.

Functional dimension

Virtue concerns what a person is **capable of doing**.

Relational dimension

Virtue benefits and serves **others**.

Theological dimension

Virtue is ultimately oriented toward **God and His character**.

Practical dimension

Virtue becomes visible through **conduct**.

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19. Virtuous Character

From this definition, **virtuous** may be described as:

A quality of personhood characterized by strength, excellence, moral integrity, wisdom, faithfulness, and beneficial action.

A virtuous person is therefore not merely someone who avoids wrongdoing.

A virtuous person develops positive qualities and puts them into practice.

Virtue involves:

- courage instead of cowardice,
- integrity instead of deceit,
- diligence instead of laziness,
- generosity instead of selfishness,
- wisdom instead of foolishness,
- self-control instead of impulsiveness,
- faithfulness instead of instability,
- compassion instead of indifference,
- holiness instead of corruption,
- love instead of self-centeredness.

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20. Conclusion

The study of **virtue** and **virtuous** across English, Greek, Hebrew, and Aramaic/Syriac reveals a much richer concept than the modern English word sometimes suggests.

The English historical development of *virtue* shows a semantic field involving **strength, moral excellence, courage, worth, ability, and efficacy**.

The Greek **ἀρετή (*aretē*)** emphasizes **excellence, goodness, moral character, merit, and qualities worthy of praise**.

The Hebrew **חַיִל (*ḥayil*)** emphasizes **strength, ability, force, capability, resources, valor, and worth**, particularly in the expression *ʾēšet ḥayil*, “woman of *ḥayil*,” in Proverbs 31:10.

The Aramaic/Syriac **ḥyl / ܚܝܠ (*ḥaylā*)** likewise contains the concepts of **force, strength, power, ability, capacity, authority, and potency**.

These words should not be treated as exact linguistic equivalents. Nevertheless, their overlapping semantic fields reveal a coherent biblical pattern.

Virtue involves **strength**, but strength directed toward good.

It involves **excellence**, but excellence grounded in character.

It involves **worth**, but worth demonstrated through conduct.

It involves **ability**, but ability placed under wisdom and righteousness.

It involves **moral goodness**, but goodness that becomes active.

The woman of Proverbs 31 illustrates this vividly. Her *ḥayil* is demonstrated through work, wisdom, provision, generosity, courage, responsibility, and fear of the LORD.

Peter's *aretē* shows that Christian virtue belongs to the process of spiritual formation.

Paul's use of *aretē* calls believers to fill their minds with what is excellent and worthy.

The result is a comprehensive biblical understanding:

Virtue is goodness possessing strength, and strength governed by goodness.

Or, more fully:

Biblical virtue is God-directed strength and excellence of character expressed through faithful, righteous, wise, and beneficial action.

Therefore, to be **virtuous** in the biblical sense is not simply to have a good reputation or to avoid particular sins. It is to become a person whose **character, capacity, choices, relationships, and actions demonstrate genuine excellence before God and toward others.**

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Final Research Thesis

The biblical concept of virtue is broader than moral purity. Across the semantic fields of Hebrew *ḥayil*, Greek *aretē*, Aramaic/Syriac *ḥyl*, and English *virtue*, the concept converges around strength, capability, excellence, worth, moral goodness, and effective action. In biblical theology, virtue is therefore best understood as strength and excellence of character directed toward God and expressed through righteous, faithful, wise, and beneficial conduct.

[Blog Version]

Virtue and Virtuous: A Biblical Word Study from Hebrew, Aramaic, Greek, and English

When we hear the words **“virtue”** and **“virtuous,”** we often think of moral goodness, purity, or someone who behaves in an upright way. Those ideas are certainly part of the meaning, but the biblical concept is much richer.

In Scripture, virtue is not merely the absence of evil. It is the presence of **strength, excellence, courage, wisdom, faithfulness, and godly character expressed through action**.

A study of the English, Greek, Hebrew, and Aramaic backgrounds of these words reveals a beautiful picture: **biblical virtue is character with strength—goodness that has become active and fruitful.**

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1. The English Meaning of “Virtue”

The English word **virtue** comes through Middle English *vertu* and Old French *vertu*, ultimately from the Latin **virtus**.

Latin *virtus* carried a much broader meaning than the modern English word. It could refer to:

- strength
- courage
- valor
- excellence
- worth
- moral goodness
- effectiveness or power

The word was therefore not originally limited to moral purity.

Likewise, the English word **virtuous** historically could describe someone who was:

- strong
- courageous
- excellent
- capable
- morally good
- worthy
- effective

Over time, “virtuous” became increasingly associated with moral purity, particularly sexual purity. But that narrower meaning does not capture the entire biblical idea.

The older sense of the word helps us understand why some older English Bible translations use **“virtue”** where modern translations use **“power.”**

In biblical English, therefore, we should always ask:

Does “virtue” here mean moral excellence, or does it carry the older sense of strength or effective power?

Context determines the answer.

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2. The Greek Word: ἀρετή — *aretē*

One of the principal Greek words associated with **virtue** in the New Testament is:

ἀρετή — *aretē*

It can mean:

- virtue
- excellence
- moral excellence
- goodness
- admirable quality
- praiseworthy character

The word emphasizes **excellence**.

This is important because biblical virtue is not simply about avoiding wrongdoing. It involves developing qualities that are genuinely good and worthy.

Consider Paul's words in **Philippians 4:8**:

“If there be any virtue, and if there be any praise, think on these things.”

The Greek word translated “virtue” is **aretē**.

Paul is directing believers toward things that are excellent and worthy of praise.

Thus *aretē* has a positive orientation.

It asks not only:

“What should I avoid?”

but also:

“What is excellent, worthy, honorable, and worthy of being cultivated in my life?”

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3. Virtue in 2 Peter 1

One of the clearest passages for understanding *aretē* is **2 Peter 1:5–7**.

Peter tells believers to add to their faith:

“virtue…”

The Greek word is again **aretē**.

Peter then gives a progression involving:

- faith
- virtue
- knowledge
- self-control
- perseverance
- godliness
- brotherly affection
- love

This gives us an important biblical understanding of virtue.

Virtue is not an isolated moral quality.

It belongs to the development of a **mature spiritual character**.

Faith is not supposed to remain merely an internal belief. It is to produce a life characterized by excellence, knowledge, self-control, perseverance, godliness, affection, and love.

Therefore:

Biblical virtue is faith expressed through an increasingly excellent character.

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4. The Hebrew Word: חַיִל — *ḥayil*

One of the most fascinating Hebrew words connected with the English idea of “virtuous” is:

חַיִל — *ḥayil* / *chayil*

This word has a broad semantic range, including:

- strength
- might
- power
- ability
- capability
- efficiency
- wealth
- resources
- valor
- force
- worth
- excellence

This is the word behind one of the most famous descriptions of a woman in the Bible.

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5. “A Virtuous Woman” — Proverbs 31:10

Proverbs 31:10 says:

“Who can find a virtuous woman? for her price is far above rubies.”

The Hebrew expression is:

אֵשֶׁת־חַיִל

ʾēšet ḥayil

Literally, it can be understood as:

“a woman of ḥayil.”

This is much richer than simply saying:

“a morally pure woman.”

The word *ḥayil* carries the ideas of **strength, capability, valor, worth, and excellence**.

This explains why different translations render the expression in different ways, such as:

- virtuous woman
- noble woman
- excellent wife
- capable woman
- woman of valor
- woman of worth

Each translation captures part of the Hebrew idea.

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6. What Does the Woman of Ḥayil Actually Do?

The rest of Proverbs 31 explains the meaning of *ḥayil*.

She is trustworthy.

She does good.

She works diligently.

She provides food for her household.

She evaluates and purchases a field.

She plants a vineyard.

She conducts business.

She makes garments.

She helps the poor.

She prepares her household for the future.

She speaks with wisdom.

She teaches kindness.

She fears the LORD.

In other words, her virtue is **visible**.

Her character produces action.

Her strength becomes service.

Her wisdom becomes provision.

Her diligence becomes productivity.

Her compassion becomes generosity.

Her fear of God becomes a way of life.

This gives us a powerful principle:

Biblical virtue is not merely what a person claims to possess; it is what becomes visible through the person's life.

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7. Virtue Is More Than Purity

This distinction is especially important.

Many people hear the word **virtuous** and immediately think:

“sexually pure.”

Sexual purity is certainly an important biblical virtue, but it is not the complete meaning of *ḥayil* or *aretē*.

A person can be sexually pure and yet be:

- dishonest,
- lazy,
- selfish,
- cruel,
- unreliable,
- arrogant,
- irresponsible.

Biblical virtue is broader.

It concerns the **whole character**.

A virtuous person is becoming the kind of person whose:

- thoughts are excellent,
- motives are honorable,
- words are trustworthy,
- actions are righteous,
- work is diligent,
- relationships are faithful,
- decisions are wise,
- resources are stewarded well,
- strength is used to serve others,
- and life is oriented toward God.

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8. The Aramaic/Syriac Connection

The Aramaic and Syriac traditions provide another interesting dimension.

A related Semitic form is:

ܚܝܠܐ — *ḥaylā / ḥayl*

This belongs to the same broad Semitic word family associated with the Hebrew **חַיִל (*ḥayil*)**.

The conceptual field includes:

strength, power, force, ability, capability, resources.

This helps us see that the ancient Semitic concept behind *ḥayil* is fundamentally connected with **strength and capacity**.

When that strength is expressed in a person, it can describe someone who is:

- capable,
- courageous,
- worthy,
- excellent,
- effective,
- strong in character.

Therefore, the idea of virtue in the biblical world is closely related to **strength put to the right use**.

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9. A Woman of Strength, Not Merely a Woman of Appearance

Proverbs 31 is therefore not presenting an ideal woman merely according to outward appearance.

Her value is found in her **character and capacity**.

She is productive.

She is wise.

She is courageous.

She is compassionate.

She is trustworthy.

She is diligent.

She is prepared.

She is generous.

And ultimately:

“A woman that feareth the LORD, she shall be praised.”

Her strength is not independent of God.

Her excellence is connected to the **fear of the LORD**.

This is crucial.

Biblical virtue is not simply human achievement.

It is **strength and excellence submitted to God**.

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10. Hebrew and Greek: Two Complementary Pictures

The Hebrew *ḥayil* and Greek *aretē* give us complementary perspectives.

Hebrew — חַיִל (*ḥayil*)

Emphasizes:

strength → capability → valor → worth → excellence

Greek — ἀρετή (*aretē*)

Emphasizes:

excellence → goodness → moral character → praiseworthy quality

Together, they provide a fuller picture.

Virtue is both:

strength of character

and:

excellence of character.

One emphasizes the **capacity** to do what is right.

The other emphasizes the **quality** of what is right.

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11. Virtue Must Become Visible

One of the most important lessons from these words is that virtue is not merely theoretical.

A person may know what is right and still fail to practice it.

Biblical virtue brings inner character into outward action.

For example:

Wisdom becomes wise decisions.

Faith becomes faithfulness.

Courage becomes righteous action.

Compassion becomes generosity.

Knowledge becomes obedience.

Self-control becomes disciplined living.

Love becomes service.

Strength becomes protection.

Wealth becomes stewardship.

Authority becomes responsibility.

This is why biblical virtue is powerful.

It transforms **character into conduct**.

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12. Virtue and the Character of Christ

The New Testament ultimately directs Christian virtue toward the character of Christ.

Jesus did not merely teach goodness.

He demonstrated it.

He showed:

- courage without cruelty,
- authority without selfishness,
- strength without oppression,
- holiness without hypocrisy,
- compassion without compromise,
- wisdom without arrogance,

- truth without deceit,
- love expressed through sacrifice.

Christian virtue therefore cannot be reduced to simply becoming a “good person.”

It means allowing one's character to be shaped according to the character of Christ.

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13. Virtue Is Strength Under God's Direction

The combined word study gives us an especially useful definition:

Virtue is strength of character directed toward what is good, excellent, righteous, and worthy.

Strength by itself is not virtue.

A powerful person can use strength destructively.

Knowledge by itself is not virtue.

A knowledgeable person can use knowledge deceptively.

Wealth by itself is not virtue.

A wealthy person can use resources selfishly.

Authority by itself is not virtue.

A leader can abuse authority.

Virtue occurs when **strength, ability, knowledge, resources, authority, and character are directed toward what is good and pleasing to God.**

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14. What Does It Mean to Be Virtuous?

To be virtuous, biblically understood, is to become a person whose inner character consistently produces righteous and excellent actions.

It means:

Your strength serves others.

Your knowledge produces wisdom.

Your faith produces faithfulness.

Your purity produces holiness.

Your authority produces protection.

Your resources produce generosity.

Your wisdom produces good decisions.

Your courage produces obedience.

Your love produces service.

This is why biblical virtue is much more than reputation.

It is **character demonstrated through life**.

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15. A Unified Definition

We can now bring the four linguistic traditions together.

English — Virtue

Excellence, moral goodness, strength, worth, and historically also efficacy or power.

Greek — ἀρετή (*aretē*)

Excellence, goodness, moral excellence, and praiseworthy character.

Hebrew — חַיִל (*ḥayil*)

Strength, ability, capability, valor, resources, worth, and excellence.

Aramaic/Syriac — ܚܝܠܐ (*ḥaylā*)

Strength, power, capacity, ability, and related qualities.

Taken together, these concepts lead us toward a rich biblical definition:

Virtue is the strength and excellence of character that enables a person to live faithfully, act righteously, serve others, and produce what is good.

And:

A virtuous person is one whose God-directed strength, character, wisdom, and conduct demonstrate genuine excellence.

Conclusion: From Strength to Excellence

The biblical meaning of **virtue** is far greater than simply "being a good person."

The Hebrew **ḥayil** reminds us of **strength, capability, valor, and worth**.

The Greek **aretē** reminds us of **excellence and moral goodness**.

The Aramaic/Syriac cognate reminds us of **strength and capacity**.

And the history of the English **virtue** reminds us that the word once carried ideas of **strength, courage, excellence, and effectiveness** alongside moral goodness.

Put together, these ideas give us a powerful biblical picture:

Virtue is goodness with strength.

Virtue is character with excellence.

Virtue is strength directed toward righteousness.

Virtue is faithfulness made visible through action.

And perhaps the clearest biblical picture is found in Proverbs 31:

אֵשֶׁת־חַיִל — *Eshet Ḥayil*
"A woman of strength, worth, capability, and excellence."

Her virtue is not merely something she possesses in theory.

It is something her life demonstrates.

That is the heart of biblical virtue: **a life in which godly character becomes visible through faithful action.**